



Historic turnout: The 2020 T20 World Cup final at the MCG set a record for women's cricket, drawing 86,174 fans to the stadium. Increasing viewership and following across both white-ball formats in the women's game means that it is now being treated as a business, which brings with it its own positives. GETTY IMAGES

Indian women's national team, tells *Sportstar*. "A lot of spinners have come into the fray, and batters quite obviously are looking to step up the runs, looking to play this game at a much faster pace. The influence of T20s has seeped into the 50-over format too, which is an entertaining turn for the format," he adds.

Raman was around the unit when India was still figuring out its T20 character. He remembers a persistent lack of confidence and fear of failure within the setup, which has finally been discarded. "ODIs were a comfort zone because they provided an opportunity for everybody to play themselves in. Until the mushrooming of T20 leagues, the girls found the format quite taxing. There were a lot of inhibitions about not being able to keep up with the pace of the format and being unable to score at the pace

we've come to see as normal in the men's game. But with time, 200 scores are getting common in T20s, and that's also changed the way ODIs are being approached," he explains.

There have been 66 instances of 300+ totals in women's ODIs since 2013 — the last time India hosted the 50-over showpiece. Of those, 35 have come after the 2022 World Cup. India has managed nine of its 13 scores of 300 or more in just the last two years, a shift the think tank has acknowledged as a priority.

Towards that end, picking horses for courses is one approach. And then there are some who tune themselves to the demands of the course, like Ellyse Perry, who completely changed her game to keep up with the flashy requirements of T20s. An undeniable addition to that club is her Royal Challengers Bengaluru teammate

Smriti Mandhana.

Elegance — an adjective almost synonymous with her — often bears the burden of slowness. Smriti's tendency to take her time to get going was a tad too relaxed for the era the game was stomping into. She had to turn from a gentle breeze to a tornado, a change half mandated by Shafali Verma's axing from the side. The result? Smriti has the most runs in the format (2100) since the 2022 World Cup. Of the 15 centuries India has scored in this cycle, eight have come from her bat.

Raman believes this evolution epitomises the transformation of the format itself. "It's a clear example of how a player can play this game for a decade and a half and suddenly discover herself and do deeds that were considered impossible."

Lisa Sthalekar, winner of the 2013